



In-ear headphones

This is a hotly contested category with sets ranging from below to ₹1,000 to well into the ₹60,000 range. In-ear headphones have a major advantage over other types of headphones and headsets in that they deliver the sound directly into your ear-canal, usually isolating background noise quite considerably. They're also a bit more secure in your ears when compared to other types of headphones and thus, all these features together make in-ear headphones the ideal headphones for everyday use. We have seen a few interesting designs pop up over the years, most notably Sony's XBA series that feature balanced armature (drivers are balanced, meaning they're both calibrated to sound exactly the same) and a few other variations with multiple drivers. Overall, we've been quite impressed with the sets that we've come across.

Zero1 Winner

Bose QC20i

To be completely honest, we weren't expecting this set to win our Zero1 award at all. The competition was very stiff, especially from the Logitech UE900, which we'll talk about in a bit. The QC20i is a remarkably well-built set and has an unusual ear-piece design, it's a bit hard to describe so we'll let the image below explain. Despite looking large and ungainly, the silicon ear-buds are comfortable and form a very nice seal in the ear canal. Oh and before we forget, the set comes with an Active Noise Cancellation (ANC) unit that's integrated into the cable. The ANC feature is particularly useful and does an exceptionally good job of cutting out background noise, especially voices. We did notice that the audio quality was very markedly improved when noise cancellation is turned on, and not just because there was less background noise, but almost seems like it's been deliberately muted to show off the feature.

The audio is very precise and the entire frequency range sounds just lovely. If we had to nit-pick, we'd say that the audio is just a little bit too harsh in the higher frequencies, especially in very heavy tracks, but that's like saying a Ferrari gets a bit jittery



Logitech UE900

Price: ₹34,995



Martin Logan Mikros 70

Price: ₹9,900



▲ HEADPHONES:

BOSE QC20I

Price: ₹22,388

above 250kmph. It's expensive, those who can afford them will not be disappointed

Worthy mentions

Logitech UE900

This was a set we really wanted to love. It seemed to have everything going for it, replaceable cables, a stratospheric price tag and a killer reputation. Sadly, while this set was definitely among the most precise sets we've heard, there were a few minor issues which ended up denying it the top spot.

The cables that these headphones come bundled with seem very sturdy and we really doubt you'll manage to damage them easily. They're also replaceable, meaning you can just pop off the driver units and replace the cable as and when you wish to. There's also a considerable assortment of ear-buds of varying sizes made of foam and silicon, so every possible ear is covered.

The audio quality of these headphones is simply stellar, however, the set does have major issues at higher volume and there's much more distortion than we would like, especially in the bass. Also, there was a very prominent hiss that seemed to be a side effect of this set being hyper-sensitive. If that wasn't enough, the awkward ritual you have to get through to actually don the set is, well, awkward.

The actual performance difference between the UE900 and QC20i is surprisingly small and, using a car analogy again, it's like comparing a Ferrari to a Porsche. You're going to have fanboys on each side arguing over the merits and demerits of one over the other. We awarded the Zero1 award to the QC20i for one very key factor, the QC20i offered the most consistent performance across varying scenarios as compared to the UE900. They're both great sets and it's definitely hard to pick one over the other. To a person who can afford either we can only say this, try them both out and see which one you prefer, either way, you'll be walking away with something special.

Martin Logan Mikros 70

This is another great set and if it wasn't for the super-expensive behemoths listed here, the Martin Logan Mikros 70 would have walked away with the Zero1 award. At this price, this set is just unbeatable. Now the audio is on the brighter side and the bass isn't as prominent as we would like, but we're only nit-picking and the only reason the audio seems to fall short is because we have the HD700 in our labs. Even if we have to be absolutely brutal while reviewing this set, it's still an excellent pair of cans.